DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Are Some Times Holier Than Others?

Daat Tevunot §172-174

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §172-174 (section 10, part 1) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 6 November 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Having finished and summarised section 9 on mazal, we begin the final section, section 10, on page 592. It has no common theme. Its five parts cover three subjects: part 1, time; parts 2 to 4, prophecy, and especially the prophecy of Moshe; part 5, how God creates something from nothing.

§172-173: time itself

The Sekhel says: I must also speak to you about time, which affects all of existence. There are differences that come from the time itself, not because something happened to make that time different, but simply because it is the time for it. As Kohelet says, there is a time for everything. The Neshamah answers that it would like to understand this.

§174: the analogy of the planets

The Sekhel gives an analogy from something we learned in Derech Hashem: mazal in the sense of flow. The initial emanation from God trickles down through many chains, spiritual ones first, and the last link is physical: the planets, stars and constellations. Each of them influences whatever the flow passes to. (A Jew who lives with the Yihud Hashem transcends that, but generally this is how it works.)

So, for example, the Gemara says that one born under Mars will be a man of blood: a shohet, a mohel or a murderer. That is the primary influence of a planet, on what is under it.

But there is also a secondary influence. At certain times of the day, each planet influences everything, not only those under it. The Rabbi mentioned that some Ashkenazim avoid making Kiddush on Friday night during a certain hour, because it is associated with one of the planets. "We don't follow this at all," he said, but that is the idea behind it.

A participant noted that influence cannot be uniform; it depends on where the other planets are and where you are. True, said the Rabbi, but the principle is that there is some influence on everyone.

The Ramhal draws the distinction. The primary influence reaches the root and essence of what receives it; those under a planet are heavily influenced by it. The secondary influence,

according to the cycle of time, is general: at its hour, a planet has influence over the whole world, but it does not have full control over anything outside its own domain. It leaves a mark, because nothing happens in vain, but a weak one. A participant added that this is cyclical, so in principle one could predict it.

The same with the higher emanations

At the bottom of page 594 the Ramhal applies the analogy. The higher, spiritual emanations each have a primary purpose: a specific shefa for a specific kind of creature. But God also gave all His emanations a cycle, so that on each day, week, month or year, one of them reaches its turn and influences the whole universe. That is not its main purpose, and its effect on everyone is minimal, but there is a mark.

Shabbat, Pesah and Shavuot

With this, says the Ramhal, we understand the holiness of the festivals and everything that depends on time, as long as we remember how different the designated emanation is from the cyclical one.

The Rabbi gave examples:

- **Shabbat.** An emanation of kedushah has its own specific purpose all week. On the seventh day it influences the entire world. Can you see or feel the difference in the world? No, but something is there.
- **Pesah.** The emanation of freedom works all year for specific things; on Pesah it is available to everyone.
- **Shavuot.** The emanation of Torah works all year for those who seek the wisdom of Torah; on Shavuot it is there for the whole world to tap into, though more lightly.

This, he said, is why Judaism is all about time, down to the minute: Shabbat comes in at one exact time and goes out at another, because once that emanation no longer reaches everything, it is over for the world.

Questions from the group

- A participant suggested that by the same logic there are times when the force of Esav has influence over the whole world. The Rabbi agreed this explains why some Hasidim do not learn Torah on Christmas: they fear that secondary influence. "We don't agree with that, but that's the idea where it's coming from."
- Another recalled that Bilam knew the exact split second when God's anger flared. Yes, said the Rabbi: as a prophet he understood which time was which. We have only a general idea from the Torah: Shabbat, Yom Tov, the month of Nisan when we avoid mourning practices because of the shefa of joy.
- Do we use other heavenly bodies besides the sun and moon? There is the berakhah on the sun every 28 years and the seasons, but very little; perhaps because the sun and moon are what we see.
- If Rosh Hashanah carries a shefa of judgment and Sukkot a shefa of joy, how could 7 October happen on a festival of joy? Because the festival's shefa is only a secondary

influence. A primary influence of another kind clearly overcame it.

The key caveat

The Rabbi added something the Ramhal takes for granted: all these influences of planets and times apply when you put yourself under them. If you truly live with the Yihud Hashem, that overrides it. A participant put it well: if you are really on that level, it is Shabbat all week.

People's stages of life

The Ramhal closes the part by saying that this also explains the different times and stages of a human life, which parallel the emanations: conception and pregnancy, youth, the teenage years and old age. Each stage has its own character, with secondary influences from other emanations too.

Summary

- Some differences between times come from the time itself, not from events: "a time for everything."
- Each planet has a primary influence on what is under it and a weaker, cyclical influence on everything at its hour.
- The higher spiritual emanations work the same way: at their appointed times they touch the whole world, lightly.
- This explains Shabbat, the festivals and the precision of Jewish time; a stronger primary influence can override a festival's shefa.
- All these influences hold only for one who puts himself under them; one who lives with the Yihud Hashem rises above them.

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